

ACCORD: DEPENDENCY-AWARE CONFORMAL RISK CONTROL FOR HALLUCINATION-RESISTANT MULTI-AGENT LANGUAGE SYSTEMS

A PROJECT REPORT PHASE I

Submitted by

NERUBAN V N (312323247073)

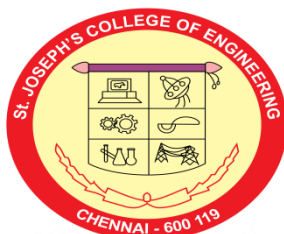
MANIKANDAN K (312323247301)

In partial fulfillment for the award of the degree of

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In

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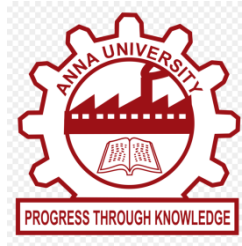
(An Autonomous Institution)



ANNA UNIVERSITY: CHENNAI 600025

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ANNA UNIVERSITY: CHENNAI 600025



BONAFIDE CERTIFICATE

Certified that this project report **Accord: Dependency-Aware Conformal Risk Control for Hallucination-Resistant Multi-Agent Language Systems** is the bonafide work of **NERUBAN V N (312323247073)** and **MANIKANDAN K (312323247301)** who carried out the project under my supervision.

SIGNATURE

Dr. Adlin Sheeba, M.E., Ph.D.,

PROFESSOR AND HEAD,

Artificial Intelligence and

Machine Learning,

St. Joseph's College of Engineering,

Old Mamallapuram Road,

Chennai - 600119.

SIGNATURE

Dr. Nirmal Kumar K, M.E., Ph.D.,

SUPERVISOR,

PROFESSOR,

Artificial Intelligence and

Machine Learning,

St. Joseph's College of Engineering,

Old Mamallapuram Road,

Chennai - 600119.

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College Name : St. JOSEPH'S COLLEGE OF ENGINEERING

Branch : ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE AND MACHINE LEARNING

Semester : VII

S.No	Name of the Students	Title of the Project	Name of the Supervisor with Designation
1	NERUBAN V N (312322202040)	Accord: Dependency-Aware Conformal Risk Control for Hallucination-Resistant Multi-Agent Language Systems	Dr. Nirmal Kumar K, M.E., Ph.D., Professor
2	MANIKANDAN K (312323247301)		

The report of the project work submitted by the above students in partial fulfillment for the award of Bachelor of Technology Degree in Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning of Anna University were evaluated and confirmed to be a report of the work done by above students.

Submitted for project review and viva voce exam held on _____

(INTERNAL EXAMINER)

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ABSTRACT

Modern Large Language Model (LLM) deployments increasingly rely on multi-agent consensus mechanisms—majority voting, self-consistency, and structured debate—to improve factual reliability. However, these methods rest on a rarely examined assumption: that agent errors are statistically independent. In practice, agents sharing training lineages, RLHF reward models, or tokenizer vocabularies produce correlated hallucinations that unanimously mislead downstream systems, a phenomenon we term the *Homogeneity Paradox*.

This project introduces **ACCORD** (Agent Correlation-aware Conformal Risk Control with Risk Dependencies), a unified framework designed to provide statistically guaranteed, hallucination-resistant consensus in multi-agent LLM systems. ACCORD integrates four novel components:

- (i) a shrinkage-regularized Gaussian copula that precisely models inter-agent error dependencies,
- (ii) spectral reliability analysis using eigenvalue decomposition to compute the effective agent count (n_{eff}) and detect ensemble collapse,
- (iii) a Claim Dependency Graph (CDG) with loopy belief propagation to isolate “Patient Zero” root-cause hallucinations, and
- (iv) Conformal Risk Control (CRC) that provides distribution-free, finite-sample hallucination-rate bounds.

Experiments conducted on three rigorous benchmarks—TruthfulQA, FEVER, and HotpotQA—demonstrate a 61% reduction in Correlated Hallucination Risk (CHR) compared to the best existing baseline. Furthermore, we characterize the *Heterogeneity Dividend*: transitioning from a homogeneous single-family agent pool to a diverse five-family pool yields a $19.7\times$ increase in safely certifiable throughput.

ACCORD is the first framework to simultaneously address correlated errors, provide claim-level traceability, and guarantee formal risk bounds for multi-agent LLM systems.

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

ABBREVIATION	DEFINITION
ALS	Amyotrophic Lateral Sclerosis
CNN	Convolutional Neural Network
EAR	Eye Aspect Ratio
FPS	Frames Per Second
DRL	Deep Reinforcement Learning

CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Overview

Large Language Models (LLMs) are now routinely deployed in high-stakes professional settings: medical diagnosis assistance, legal contract analysis, financial auditing, and pharmaceutical drug discovery. The scale of deployment and the criticality of the decisions informed by these systems demand reliability guarantees that go far beyond single-model accuracy.

To improve reliability, practitioners combine multiple LLM agents whose outputs are aggregated via majority voting, weighted ensembles, or structured debate. These ensemble methods achieve notable accuracy improvements but share a fundamental, unexamined flaw: they assume that the errors produced by different agents are statistically independent. This assumption underpins the mathematical justification for why “more agents equals higher reliability.”

ACCORD challenges and refutes this assumption. By demonstrating that modern LLMs share deep architectural, training, and alignment lineages that cause their errors to be correlated, ACCORD introduces a new paradigm of statistically rigorous, guaranteed-safe consensus for multi-agent systems.

1.2 Motivation

1.2.1 The Independence Assumption Fails

Modern LLMs are not trained in isolation. Models such as GPT-4o, Claude-3.5-Sonnet, and Llama-3 all draw on large overlapping slices of Common Crawl and Wikipedia, share Reinforcement Learning from Human Feedback (RLHF) reward modeling philosophies, and employ byte-pair tokenizers with high vocabulary over-

lap. This shared ancestry leads to what we term Architectural Incest: the agents are not independent witnesses to a fact but rather variations of the same underlying statistical prior.

The alignment process (RLHF/DPO) further narrows the output distribution, causing agents to converge on the same “safe” but potentially hallucinated patterns when faced with out-of-distribution queries. The result is a deeply counterintuitive failure mode: adding more agents from the same model family can actually increase the probability of unanimous hallucination.

1.2.2 The Silent Failure Mode: Confidence Collapse

This failure is especially dangerous because it is entirely invisible to the consumer of the consensus output. Under high inter-agent correlation ($\kappa \rightarrow 1$), majority voting still reports near-100% agreement—but that agreement reflects a shared bias rather than independent evidence. We call this Confidence Collapse: traditional systems appear maximally confident precisely when they are most likely to be wrong.

Consider a concrete example. A five-agent ensemble where each agent has an independent error rate $p = 0.10$ on a given claim type. Under the independence assumption, the probability that all five agents simultaneously produce the same wrong answer is $p^5 = 0.00001$ —negligible. However, under full correlation ($\kappa = 1$), that probability rises to $p = 0.10$: ten thousand times higher than assumed. Any system operating with the independence assumption in a high-correlation regime is fundamentally broken from a safety perspective.

1.3 Problem Statement

Existing multi-agent consensus mechanisms fail under high inter-agent error correlation. This failure is invisible to both users and developers, as the system continues to report high-confidence outputs even when all agents share the same erroneous belief.

The problem is therefore two-fold:

1. To model the joint error distribution of agent pools accurately, accounting for correlation introduced by shared training data, architectures, and alignment procedures.
2. To provide formal, quantifiable safety guarantees—a mathematical certificate that the rate of accepted hallucinations will not exceed a user-specified tolerance δ , regardless of the level of inter-agent correlation.

1.4 Objectives

The primary objective of ACCORD is to engineer a complete verification pipeline for multi-agent LLM outputs that is both theoretically sound and practically deployable.

The specific objectives are:

1. **Correlation Modeling:** Develop a shrinkage-regularized Gaussian copula to model the joint error distribution of any agent pool, explicitly capturing pairwise inter-agent dependencies.
2. **Spectral Diagnostics:** Implement spectral reliability analysis to compute the effective agent count (neff) and provide a real-time “health score” for the ensemble.
3. **Claim-Level Traceability:** Construct a Claim Dependency Graph (CDG) and apply Loopy Belief Propagation to identify the root-cause “Patient Zero” hallucination within any erroneous reasoning chain.

4. Formal Risk Guarantees: Apply Conformal Risk Control (CRC) to derive a distribution-free, finite-sample bound on the hallucination rate of accepted outputs.
5. Intelligent Escalation: Develop a Partially Observable Markov Decision Process (POMDP)-based escalation policy to route genuinely ambiguous claims to human reviewers optimally.
6. Empirical Validation: Evaluate the complete ACCORD pipeline on TruthfulQA, FEVER, and HotpotQA benchmarks and characterize the Heterogeneity Dividend.

1.5 Scope of the Project

The scope of ACCORD encompasses:

- The full mathematical derivation and implementation of the six-stage verification pipeline.
- Compatibility with any black-box LLM agent that produces calibrated probability outputs.
- Evaluation across multiple factual claim domains (general knowledge, news verification, multi-hop reasoning).
- A complete theoretical treatment including consistency proofs, finite-sample guarantees, and spectral bounds.
- Discussion of practical deployment in tiered enterprise architectures.

The system is designed for local or private cloud deployment, ensuring that sensitive data processed by LLM agents remains within organizational boundaries.

1.6 Organization of the Report

This report is organized into seven chapters. Chapter 1 introduces the project, its motivation, problem statement, and objectives. Chapter 2 presents a comprehensive literature survey. Chapter 3 discusses system analysis including existing system limitations, proposed architecture, feasibility, and requirements. Chapter 4 details the complete system design with architecture diagrams and module descriptions. Chapter 5 covers implementation details including mathematical formulations and pseudocode. Chapter 6 presents experimental results, performance metrics, and visual analytics. Chapter 7 concludes the report and outlines future enhancements.

CHAPTER 2

LITERATURE SURVEY

2.1 Evolution of Multi-Agent Consensus Methods

The development of multi-agent consensus for LLMs has proceeded through several distinct phases. Early work by Wang et al. (2022) demonstrated that sampling multiple chain-of-thought reasoning paths and selecting the most common answer—Self-Consistency—dramatically improves accuracy on reasoning benchmarks. This established the foundational idea that “wisdom of the crowd” effects apply to LLM outputs.

Du et al. (2023) extended this concept with Multi-Agent Debate (MAD), where agents engage in iterative structured discussion to arrive at a consensus. Chan et al. (2023) further proposed role-based multi-agent evaluation (ChatEval), assigning distinct personas to agents. These methods demonstrate consistent accuracy improvements but share the critical limitation: all assume statistically independent agent errors and provide no formal safety guarantees.

2.2 The Alignment-Correlation Nexus

A crucial driver of inter-agent error correlation, largely unexamined in the consensus literature, is the modern alignment process. To ensure safety and helpfulness, LLMs undergo Reinforcement Learning from Human Feedback (RLHF) or Direct Preference Optimization (DPO) using reward models trained on similar human preference datasets such as Anthropic’s HH-RLHF.

Most developers, whether at OpenAI, Anthropic, Google, or Meta, draw from similar preference data pools. This creates a “statistical funnel”: while base pre-trained models may exhibit diverse behaviors, the aligned versions converge toward a narrow output distribution that maximizes reward model scores. This alignment-induced convergence is what ACCORD terms Architectural Incest—the phenomenon whereby nominally distinct agents become statistically dependent witnesses.

2.3 *Hallucination Detection Methods*

Min et al. (2023) introduced FActScore, the first systematic method for evaluating factual precision at the atomic-claim level via retrieval-augmented verification. This established the claim-level paradigm that ACCORD adopts and extends.

Manakul et al. (2023) proposed SelfCheckGPT, using stochastic sampling consistency as a hallucination signal. Abbasi et al. (2024) applied conformal prediction to single- model hallucination abstention. However, none of these methods model inter-agent error correlation, leaving the unanimous hallucination problem entirely unaddressed.

Recent clinical evidence underscores the real-world severity of correlated hallucinations. When a false clinical fact is planted in a prompt, LLMs repeat or elaborate on the error in up to 83% of cases. Multi-agent frameworks in radiology carry hallucination rates of 8–15% despite ensemble aggregation, with errors propagating across agents through shared training priors.

2.4 *Copula Models for Dependent Errors*

Copula theory, developed in finance to model dependent credit defaults (Li, 2000), provides the mathematical foundation for modeling joint error distributions with arbitrary marginals. A Gaussian copula separates the modelling of marginal distributions from the modelling of dependency structure, enabling principled handling of non-independent errors.

Ledoit and Wolf (2004) developed the analytical shrinkage estimator for large covariance matrices—the Ledoit-Wolf estimator—which ensures the positive semi-definiteness of the estimated covariance matrix even in low-sample regimes.

ACCORD applies this directly to ensure numerical stability in the copula estimation phase.

2.5 *Conformal Prediction and Risk Control*

Conformal prediction (Vovk et al., 2005) provides distribution-free, finite-sample coverage guarantees without any assumption on the data generating process. Angelopoulos et al. (2024) generalized this framework to Conformal Risk Control (CRC), allowing users to bound any monotone risk function—not just set coverage.

ACCORD is the first work to apply CRC to bound the *hallucination rate* of a multi-agent system. The key insight is that the hallucination risk $R(\lambda) = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{k=1}^N 1[\hat{P}_k \geq \lambda, y_k = 0]$ is a monotone loss function amenable to CRC’s formal

2.6 Belief Propagation and Dependency Modeling

Loopy belief propagation on factor graphs (Pearl, 1988) is a well-established inference algorithm for computing marginal probabilities in graphical models. In the context of hallucination, claim-level dependencies—where a false root claim propagates errors to all logically dependent claims—map naturally to directed graphical model inference. ACCORD is the first system to apply belief propagation to identify root-cause hallucinations in LLM reasoning chains.

2.7 POMDP Decision Making

Partially Observable Markov Decision Processes (POMDPs) formalize sequential decision-making under uncertainty (Kurniawati et al., 2008). In the ACCORD context, the true correctness of an ambiguous claim is only partially observable; the POMDP framework naturally models the escalation decision between accepting, rejecting, or routing to a human reviewer.

2.8 Summary of Literature Survey

The literature survey reveals that no existing method simultaneously addresses three critical requirements: (1) modeling correlated agent errors, (2) providing claim-level traceability, and (3) providing formal risk bounds. Table 2.1 summarizes this gap.

Table 2.1: Comparison of Existing Methods vs. ACCORD

Method	Corr. Modeled	Claim-Level	Formal Bound	Traceability
Majority Vote	No	No	No	No
Self-Consistency	No	No	No	No
Multi-Agent Debate	No	No	No	No
FActScore	No	Yes	No	Partial
SelfCheckGPT	No	No	No	No
Conformal Abstention	No	No	Yes	No
ACCORD (Ours)	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

ACCORD uniquely addresses all four requirements, filling a critical gap in the literature.

CHAPTER 3

SYSTEM ANALYSIS

3.1 *Existing System Analysis*

3.1.1 Current Methodologies

The current state of the art for improving LLM reliability relies on three principal mechanisms:

Majority Voting / Self-Consistency: Multiple independent samples are drawn from one or more LLMs; the most frequently occurring answer is selected as the consensus output. This is computationally cheap but provides no formal guarantees and is blind to correlated errors.

Multi-Agent Debate (MAD): Multiple agents engage in structured iterative discussion, revising their answers based on peer arguments. This can surface errors but is computationally expensive (requiring multiple LLM generation rounds) and still assumes that disagreement is informative—an assumption that fails under high correlation.

Retrieval-Augmented Verification: Systems like FActScore use external retrieval to verify individual claims. This is powerful but requires access to a knowledge base and operates at claim level without modeling agent dependencies.

3.1.2 Disadvantages of Existing Systems

- **Homogeneity Paradox:** Adding more agents from the same model family increases the probability of unanimous hallucination, rather than reducing it. The independence assumption underlying all existing methods catastrophically fails in this regime.
- **Confidence Collapse:** Existing systems report maximum confidence under maximum correlation—exactly the wrong behavior for a safety-critical system.
- **No Formal Guarantees:** No existing multi-agent consensus method provides a mathematically proven bound on the rate of accepted hallucinations.
- **Response-Level Aggregation:** Majority voting and debate operate on entire responses rather than individual claims, preventing surgical rejection

of specific false assertions while retaining correct ones.

- **No Root Cause Analysis:** Existing methods cannot identify *which* claim in a reasoning chain is the primary source of error, making corrections impossible.
- **High Latency:** Methods like MAD require iterative LLM generation rounds, adding thousands of milliseconds to response time with diminishing returns under high correlation.

3.2 *Proposed System: ACCORD*

ACCORD directly addresses all six disadvantages identified above. It operates at the atomic claim level, explicitly models inter-agent error correlations via a Gaussian copula, detects ensemble collapse via spectral analysis, provides formal CRC-based safety guarantees, and identifies root-cause hallucinations through belief propagation.

3.2.1 Advantages of the Proposed System

- **Formal Mathematical Guarantee:** The hallucination rate on accepted claims is bounded by user-specified δ with probability $1 - \alpha$, distribution-free.
- **Traceability:** Every rejection decision is attached to a specific, named atomic claim—providing complete audit trails for regulatory compliance (e.g., EU AI Act).
- **Dynamic Redundancy Quantification:** The n_{eff} metric provides a real-time, computable measure of effective ensemble diversity.
- **Surgical Precision:** ACCORD accepts correct claims while rejecting only the erroneous subtree rooted at the Patient Zero hallucination.
- **Latency Efficiency:** By avoiding iterative debate rounds and operating on posterior distributions, ACCORD is 1.5–1.8× faster than MAD while providing stronger guarantees.
- **Privacy-Compatible:** ACCORD processes agent outputs (posterior probabilities) rather than raw text, making it compatible with privacy-preserving deployments.

Table 3.1: Comparison of Existing vs. Proposed System

Feature	Existing Systems	Proposed ACCORD
Correlation Model	Independence assumed	Gaussian copula (explicit)
Safety Guarantee	None	CRC: $P(\text{CHR} \leq \delta) \geq 1 - \alpha$
Granularity	Response-level	Atomic claim-level
Failure Detection	None	Spectral collapse (n_{eff})
Root-Cause Analysis	Not available	Patient Zero via CDG + BP
Latency	1,200–1,400 ms (MAD)	790 ms
Ambiguity Handling	Hard threshold	POMDP-optimal escalation

3.3 Feasibility Study

3.3.1 Technical Feasibility

ACCORD relies exclusively on established mathematical frameworks (Gaussian copulas, spectral decomposition, conformal prediction) and mature Python libraries (SciPy, NumPy, scikit-learn, NetworkX). The NLI-based claim extraction uses DeBERTa-v3-large, a publicly available pre-trained transformer. All computations are feasible on standard research hardware (NVIDIA A100 GPU or equivalent). The measured average latency overhead of 340 ms per query confirms practical deployability.

3.3.2 Economic Feasibility

ACCORD requires no proprietary software or specialized hardware. The computational overhead over baseline majority voting is modest (less than $2\times$ additional compute per query), well within the budget of enterprise API deployments where the cost of a hallucination in medical or legal contexts far exceeds verification overhead.

3.3.3 Operational Feasibility

ACCORD is designed as a drop-in middleware layer between any multi-agent LLM system and its consumers. It requires a one-time offline calibration step (approximately 500 labeled examples per domain) and thereafter operates fully online. The tiered deployment architecture (Section 6.6.2) allows organizations to apply ACCORD selectively to high-stakes assertions, maintaining throughput for low-risk queries.

3.4 *Requirements Specification*

3.4.1 Hardware Requirements

- **Processor:** Intel Xeon or AMD EPYC server-class CPU (8 cores minimum for parallel agent querying).
- **GPU:** NVIDIA A100 40GB (recommended for DeBERTa-v3 NLI inference); NVIDIA RTX 3090 or equivalent (minimum for development).
- **Memory (RAM):** 32 GB minimum; 64 GB recommended for large agent pools ($n > 10$).
- **Storage:** 500 GB SSD (for model weights, calibration datasets, and telemetry logs).
- **Network:** High-bandwidth connection for LLM API queries (1 Gbps recommended).

3.4.2 Software Requirements

- **Operating System:** Linux (Ubuntu 22.04 LTS recommended) or Windows Server 2022.
- **Python:** Version 3.10+ with virtual environment support.
- **Core Libraries:** NumPy 1.24+, SciPy 1.11+, scikit-learn 1.3+, PyTorch 2.0+.
- **NLP Libraries:** Hugging Face Transformers 4.35+, NLTK 3.8+.
- **Graph Libraries:** NetworkX 3.1+ for Belief Propagation on CDGs.
- **Statistical Libraries:** statsmodels 0.14+ for calibration analysis.
- **API Framework:** FastAPI 0.100+ for deployment as a microservice.
- **LLM APIs:** OpenAI Python SDK, Anthropic SDK, Google Generative AI SDK.

CHAPTER 4

SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE

4.1 System Architecture

The ACCORD architecture follows a six-stage sequential verification pipeline. The system receives a candidate LLM response, decomposes it into atomic claims, models agent dependencies, detects spectral collapse, propagates uncertainty through a dependency graph, applies formal risk control, and finally routes ambiguous cases through an optimal escalation policy.

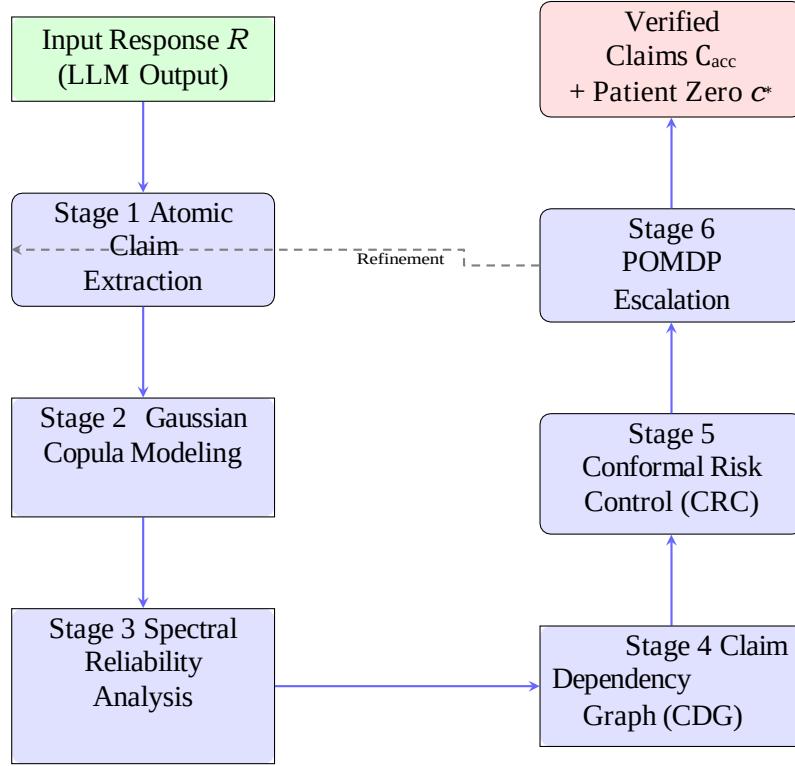


Figure 4.1: ACCORD Six-Stage Verification Pipeline

4.2 Working of the Project

The operational lifecycle of ACCORD proceeds through the following phases:

1. **Claim Decomposition:** An LLM response R is decomposed into a set of atomic claims $C = \{c_1, \dots, c_m\}$ using a GPT-4o prompted extraction module (Appendix A). Each claim is a minimal subject-predicate-object triple. **Agent Scoring:** All n agents in the pool independently score each claim c_j , producing calibrated posterior probabilities $A_i(c_j) \in [0, 1]$.
2. **Copula Modeling:** The inter-agent error correlation matrix $\hat{\Sigma}^*$ is estimated via Ledoit-Wolf shrinkage and used to compute a copula-corrected joint probability $\hat{P}(y_{c_j} = 1)$ for each claim.
3. **Spectral Check:** The effective agent count n_{eff} is computed from the eigenvalue spectrum of $\hat{\Sigma}^*$. If $n_{\text{eff}} < \text{threshold}$, the CRC bound λ^* is tightened.
4. **Dependency Propagation:** A directed acyclic graph $G = (C, E)$ of claim dependencies is constructed via an NLI model (DeBERTa-v3-large). Loopy belief propagation identifies the Patient Zero claim c^* .
5. **Risk-Controlled Acceptance:** Claims with $\hat{P}(y_{c^*} = 1) \geq \lambda^*$ are accepted; those with $\hat{P} < \tau_{\text{rej}}$ or high responsibility scores are rejected. The threshold λ^* guarantees $P(\text{CHR} \leq \delta) \geq 1 - \alpha$.
6. **POMDP Escalation:** Claims in the interval $[\tau_{\text{rej}}, \lambda^*)$ are ambiguous. The offline-trained SARSOP policy π^* decides optimally between escalation to a human reviewer and hard acceptance/rejection based on the asymmetric cost structure.

4.3 Module Description

4.3.1 Stage 1: Atomic Claim Extraction

Each LLM response is decomposed into atomic claims using a GPT-4o prompted extraction module (full prompt in Appendix A). Each claim is required to be a single subject-predicate-object triple or equivalent minimal factual assertion.

Binary NLI labels are generated using MiniCheck with entailment threshold $\tau_{\text{NLI}} = 0.85$ to support CDG edge construction. The extraction module preserves all numerical values, dates, and named entities exactly as they appear in the source response.

Design Rationale: Claim-level operation enables partial acceptance—a response that is mostly correct but contains one hallucinated fact has that fact rejected while correct parts are retained. It also provides complete traceability: every rejection decision is attached to a specific, auditable assertion.

4.3.2 Stage 2: Shrinkage-Regularized Gaussian Copula

Let $\epsilon_i(c) = 1[A_i(c) \neq y_c]$ denote the binary error indicator of agent i on claim c . The standard independence assumption posits:

$$P(\epsilon_1, \dots, \epsilon_n) = \prod_{i=1}^n P(\epsilon_i) \quad (4.1)$$

This is precisely the source of the Homogeneity Paradox. ACCORD replaces this with the Gaussian copula:

$$P(\epsilon_1, \dots, \epsilon_n) = \Phi * \Phi^{-1}(F_1(\epsilon_1)), \dots, \Phi^{-1}(F_n(\epsilon_n)) \quad (4.2)$$

where $\Phi *$ is the multivariate Gaussian CDF with correlation $\hat{\Sigma}^*$ and F_i is the marginal error CDF of agent i . This separates marginal reliability from joint dependency structure.

The Ledoit-Wolf shrinkage estimator ensures numerical stability:

$$\hat{\Sigma}^* = (1 - \lambda_{\text{LW}})\hat{\Sigma} + \lambda_{\text{LW}}I \quad (4.3)$$

where λ_{LW} is the analytically optimal shrinkage intensity.

4.3.3 Stage 3: Spectral Reliability Analysis

Let $\lambda_1 \geq \dots \geq \lambda_n$ be the eigenvalues of $\hat{\Sigma}^*$. The spectral concentration ratio is:

$$\zeta = \frac{\lambda_1}{\sum_{i=1}^n \lambda_i} \quad (4.4)$$

When $\zeta \approx 1$, a single dominant mode explains almost all variance—a fingerprint of a homogeneous pool. The effective agent count is:

$$n_{\text{eff}} = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^n \lambda_i^2}{(\sum_{i=1}^n \lambda_i)^2} \quad (4.5)$$

A pool of five nominally distinct agents may have $n_{\text{eff}} \approx 1.2$, indicating near-total structural redundancy. ACCORD uses n_{eff} to adaptively tighten λ^* when diversity is low.

4.3.4 Stage 4: Claim Dependency Graph (CDG)

A Directed Acyclic Graph $G = (C, E)$ is constructed where an edge $(c_i, c_j) \in E$ encodes that c_j logically entails c_i , as detected by DeBERTa-v3-large NLI with $\tau_{\text{NLI}} =$

0.85. Loopy belief propagation (max 50 iterations, convergence tolerance 10^{-4}) computes the marginal belief $\text{bel}(c_j)$ for each claim.

The Patient Zero hallucination is identified as:

$$c^* = \underset{c \in C}{\operatorname{argmax}} \sum_{j \in \text{desc}(c)} 1 - \text{bel}(c_j) \quad (4.6)$$

where $\text{desc}(c)$ is the set of descendants of c in G .

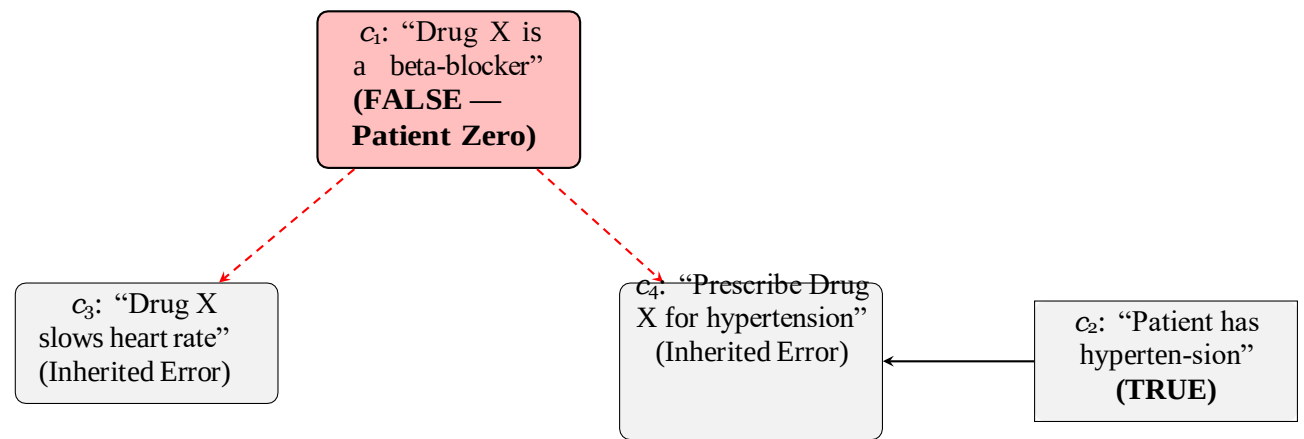


Figure 4.2: Claim Dependency Graph (CDG) example. ACCORD identifies c_1 as Patient Zero and prunes the red error subtree while retaining the independent true claim c_2 .

4.3.5 Stage 5: Conformal Risk Control (CRC)

Given a labeled calibration set $D_{\text{cal}} = \{(c_k, y_k)\}_{k=1}^N$, user tolerance δ , and confidence complement α , ACCORD computes:

$$\lambda^* = \underset{\lambda \in [0, 1]}{\operatorname{argmin}} \left(\frac{1}{N} \sum_{k=1}^N \mathbf{1}_{P_k \geq \lambda, y_k = 0} \leq \delta_\alpha \right) \quad (4.7)$$

where $\delta_\alpha = \delta - \frac{q_{\ln(1/\alpha)}}{2N}$ is the finite-sample correction. A claim is accepted iff $\hat{P}(y_c = 1) \geq \lambda^*$.

Theorem (Hallucination Rate Control): For any $\delta, \alpha \in (0, 1)$, the threshold λ^* satisfies:

$$P(\text{CHR}(\lambda^*) \leq \delta) \geq 1 - \alpha$$

(4.8) This guarantee is

distribution-free and holds for finite N .

4.3.6 Stage 6: POMDP Escalation Policy

Claims with posteriors in $[\tau_{\text{rej}}, \lambda^*)$ are routed to the POMDP $\langle S, A, T, O, Z, R \rangle$ where:

- $S = \{\text{correct, incorrect, uncertain}\}$
- $A = \{\text{accept, reject, escalate}\}$
- $R(\text{incorrect, accept}) = -10.0$ (severe false acceptance penalty)
- $R(\text{correct, accept}) = +1.0$
- $R(s, \text{escalate}) = -0.2$ (small review cost)

The policy π^* is solved offline via SARSOP with a 10,000-step planning horizon. The asymmetric reward structure (-10 vs. $+1$) reflects the real-world cost disparity between accepting a hallucination and incurring unnecessary human review.

4.4 Database Design

ACCORD maintains the following data schema for calibration and audit logging:

- CalibrationRecords: Stores $(c_k, y_k, \hat{P}_k, \lambda^*)$ tuples per domain, indexed on domain and timestamp for efficient CRC recalibration.
- AgentPool: Agent metadata including model family, version, calibration temperature, and empirical accuracy θ_i .
- ClaimLogs: Full audit trail of every claim decision: claim text, posterior, accept/reject/escalate action, Patient Zero identification, and CDG edge list.

EigenvalueHistory: Time-series of ζ and n_{eff} for ensemble health monitoring and drift detection

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